



But for me perhaps the most important factor in holding India together is what Ashish Nandy has called its salad bowl culture. India has a unique ability to allow different cultures and different religions to live side-by-side, retaining their own identity. Recently I was in Varanasi where the well-known Mahant of the Sankat Mochan temple, Veer Bhadra Mishra, told me about his childhood when Hindus and Muslims in his village would attend each others' weddings and festivals, but the hosts would provide separate food for their guests. That would be anathema to many in these days when the common belief seems to be that we should have a soup culture in which everyone is mixed up and all lose their individual identity. This is considered to be egalitarian, but then egalitarians sometimes forget that we never have been—nor is there any sign we ever will be—equal, or indeed the same.

Veer Bhadra Mishra is a bit of a Jeremiah him-

question a Muslim woman's right to wear a burqa, or a Sikh's right to wear a turban.

All this does not mean that India should not take the threat of religious fundamentalism seriously, but to do that it also has to acknowledge the dangers of a certain type of secularism. The renowned religious writer Karen Armstrong, who was once a Roman Catholic nun, has written, "fundamentalism exists in a symbiotic relationship with an aggressive liberalism or secularism, and, under attack, increasingly becomes more bitter, extreme, and excessive." I do find that in India there are secularists who are so aggressive that they do not allow any room for religion in public, or indeed private life. This is not the same as the pseudo secularism that BJP leaders talk about. They are talking about their claim that undue preference is given to minorities. The secularism I am talking about fails to acknowledge the importance of religion in many, many



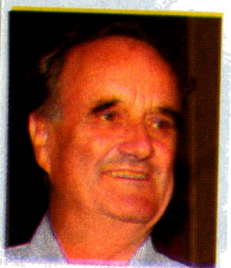
FORWARD MARCH: The diversity of the Indian Army is its strength

self. He said to me, "Hindus and Muslims were living very happily together but that has come under threat because of politicians." One of the greatest strengths of India is that the Hindu majority does still live together, peacefully for the most part, with the world's second largest Muslim population. There are those who would disturb the peace, some Muslim clergy and some Hindu preachers, as well as some politicians, but how successful are they? I was still the BBC correspondent at the time of Ayodhya and when the riots broke out; I was asked time and time again whether this was the end of India's secularism. I always used to reply, "In my experience, in India things go up very rapidly but they come down again rapidly too." For all the hatred spewed out by both sides at that time, millions of Muslims today still educate their children in their religion, go to mosques daily to say their prayers, and of course wear whatever clothes they believe their faith demands. When I am in Britain, I often tell people that it would be unthinkable for the vast majority of Indians to

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people's lives, and the impossibility of drawing an absolute, hard and fast line, between the role of faith in private and public life. Mahatma Gandhi did not do that. I am sometimes made aware of this aggressive secularism when I am accused of supporting Hindutva just because I write about Hinduism. I firmly believe in Indian secularism but not in the sort of secularism which has no time and no respect for people's religion.

I recently read of a report by Doudou Diene, the United Nations Special Rapporteur on contemporary forms of racism, racial discrimination, xenophobia, and related intolerance. In it, he criticised the spread of Christianophobia in Europe and urged the return to a correct balance of "defending the secular and protecting religious freedom". I detect in certain secular quarters in India a Hinduphobia, and if there is one threat I do see to the unity of India, it is not maintaining the balance Diene talks about. This surely means that the two national parties should realise they are in danger of forging the symbiotic relationship Armstrong described by continuing their shout-ing match between Hindutva and secularism.



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